Return to Your First Love

Jesus sees our faithful work, but he wants our love even more; when love has cooled, he calls us to remember, repent and return.

Main passage	Revelation 2:1-7 (KJV)
Topic	Backsliders
Audience	adults
Length	about 45 minutes
Status	Draft: written by AI from the library, not yet reviewed by Dave

Suggested timing

Opening	4 min
Scripture	3 min
Background	5 min
Teaching point 1: Jesus knows our works	7 min
Teaching point 2: Busy, but losing love	7 min
Teaching point 3: Remember, repent, return	7 min
Discussion questions	7 min
Application	3 min
Closing prayer	2 min
Total	45 min

Opening (4 min)

Ask married couples (or anyone with a long friendship): "What did you do when you were first in love that you do not do as much now?" Let people laugh and share. Then ask: "Does love grow cold suddenly, or slowly?" Today Jesus speaks to a church that was busy, faithful, and slowly cooling.

Scripture (3 min)

Revelation 2:1-7

[1] Unto the angel of the church of Ephesus write; These things saith he that holdeth the seven stars in his right hand, who walketh in the midst of the seven golden candlesticks; [2] I know thy works, and thy labour, and thy patience, and how thou canst not bear them which are evil: and thou hast tried them which say they are apostles, and are not, and hast found them liars: [3] And hast borne, and hast patience, and for my name's sake hast laboured, and hast not fainted. [4] Nevertheless I have somewhat against thee, because thou hast left thy first love. [5] Remember therefore from whence thou art fallen, and repent, and do the first works; or else I will come unto thee quickly, and will remove thy candlestick out of his place, except thou

repent. [6] But this thou hast, that thou hatest the deeds of the Nicolaitans, which I also hate. [7] He that hath an ear, let him hear what the Spirit saith unto the churches; To him that overcometh will I give to eat of the tree of life, which is in the midst of the paradise of God.

Read the passage aloud.

Background (5 min)

Revelation 2-3 contains seven short letters from the risen Jesus to seven churches in what is now western Turkey. Ephesus was the first and most important, a great port city with a famous temple of Diana. Paul had spent over two years there (Acts 19), and the church had good teachers, including Timothy.

Some forty years later, the church was still orthodox and hard-working. It tested false teachers and rejected the Nicolaitans (apparently a group teaching compromise with immorality). But something essential had slipped.

Teacher note: Barnes understands "the angel" of the church (v. 1) as its minister or leader; others take it as a heavenly messenger. Either way, the message is for the whole church: "hear what the Spirit saith unto the churches" (v. 7).

Teaching point 1: Jesus knows our works (7 min)

"I know thy works, and thy labour, and thy patience" (v. 2). Jesus noticed everything: their hard work, their endurance, their stand against false teaching. Nothing done for him is unseen. This is a comfort for every faithful, unnoticed servant.

Supporting verses

Revelation 2:1-3: Unto the angel of the church of Ephesus write; These things saith he that holdeth the seven stars in his right hand, who walketh in the midst of the seven golden candlesticks; I know thy works, and thy labour, and thy patience, and how thou canst not bear them which are evil: and thou hast tried them which say they are apostles, and are not, and hast found them liars: And hast borne, and hast patience, and for my name's sake hast laboured, and hast not fainted.

Hebrews 6:10: For God is not unrighteous to forget your work and labour of love, which ye have shewed toward his name, in that ye have ministered to the saints, and do minister.

1 Corinthians 15:58: Therefore, my beloved brethren, be ye stedfast, unmoveable, always abounding in the work of the Lord, forasmuch as ye know that your labour is not in vain in the Lord.

> *"I know thy works. The common formula with which all the epistles to the seven churches are introduced."*
> — Albert Barnes, Notes on the New Testament, on Revelation 2:2

> *"you have not given way to murmuring or complaints in trial"*
> — Albert Barnes, Notes on the New Testament, on Revelation 2:3

Handout blanks (answers)

Jesus said, "I know thy **works**."

Nothing done for Jesus goes **unseen (unnoticed)**.

Teaching point 2: Busy, but losing love (7 min)

"Nevertheless I have somewhat against thee, because thou hast left thy first love" (v. 4). They had not lost correct belief or hard work; they had lost love: love for Christ, and probably love for one another. It is possible to keep doing all the right things while the heart slowly cools.

Supporting verses

Revelation 2:4: Nevertheless I have somewhat against thee, because thou hast left thy first love.

Matthew 24:12: And because iniquity shall abound, the love of many shall wax cold.

Jeremiah 2:2: Go and cry in the ears of Jerusalem, saying, Thus saith the LORD; I remember thee, the kindness of thy youth, the love of thine espousals, when thou wentest after me in the wilderness, in a land that was not sown.

> *"Notwithstanding this general commendation, there are things which I cannot approve."*
> — Albert Barnes, Notes on the New Testament, on Revelation 2:4

Handout blanks (answers)

Thou hast left thy first **love**.

We can keep doing the right things while the heart **cools**.

Teaching point 3: Remember, repent, return (7 min)

Jesus gives three steps (v. 5). Remember how it was when you first came to him. Repent: turn around. Return and "do the first works" again, the things you did when love was fresh. The warning is serious: a church without love may lose its lampstand. The promise is wonderful: the one who overcomes will eat of the tree of life (v. 7).

Supporting verses

Revelation 2:5-7: Remember therefore from whence thou art fallen, and repent, and do the first works; or else I will come unto thee quickly, and will remove thy candlestick out of his place, except thou repent. But this thou hast, that thou hatest the deeds of the Nicolaitans, which I also hate. He that hath an ear, let him hear what the Spirit saith unto the churches; To him that overcometh will I give to eat of the tree of life, which is in the midst of the paradise of God.

Hosea 14:1-4: O Israel, return unto the LORD thy God; for thou hast fallen by thine iniquity. Take with you words, and turn to the LORD: say unto him, Take away all iniquity, and receive us graciously: so will we render the calves of our lips. Asshur shall not save us; we will not ride upon horses: neither will we say any more to the work of our hands, Ye are our gods: for in thee the fatherless findeth mercy. I will heal their backsliding, I will love them freely: for mine anger is turned away from him.

Luke 15:20: And he arose, and came to his father. But when he was yet a great way off, his father saw him, and had compassion, and ran, and fell on his neck, and kissed him.

> *"Consider the state of grace in which you once stood; the happiness, love, and joy which you felt when ye received remission of sins"*
> — Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on Revelation 2:5

Handout blanks (answers)

Remember therefore from whence thou art **fallen**, and repent.

Do the **first** works.

Discussion questions (7 min)

1. What did Jesus commend in the Ephesian church? Why do you think he started there?

Their work, endurance and discernment; he is fair and encouraging, and wants them to know he sees.

2. How can a church or a Christian be doctrinally sound and hard-working but still lose its first love?

Duty replaces devotion; routines continue while the heart drifts; truth is defended without love.

3. What were the "first works" in your early Christian life?

Answers will vary: eager prayer, reading Scripture, telling others, joyful worship, serving.

4. What practical steps help rekindle love for Christ?

Remembering his grace, confession, time in his word and prayer, worship, serving others in love.

Application (3 min)

Spend time this week remembering: write down how you came to faith and what Jesus meant to you then. Choose one "first work" to take up again. Pray each day: "Lord, restore my first love."

Closing prayer (2 min)

Lord Jesus, you know our works, and you know our hearts. Forgive us where our love for you and for one another has grown cold. Help us remember where we have fallen from, repent, and do the first works again. Rekindle our first love, and keep us faithful until we eat of the tree of life. Amen.

Sources quoted

Albert Barnes, Notes on the New Testament, on Revelation 2:2

Albert Barnes, Notes on the New Testament, on Revelation 2:3

Albert Barnes, Notes on the New Testament, on Revelation 2:4

Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on Revelation 2:5

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